

Chapter One

It was the best of times, it was the worst of times, it was the age of wisdom, it was the age of foolishness. The travellers pressed on through the long night, uncertain of what the dawn would bring but certain that they must keep moving.¹ Nobody spoke.

In the morning the valley opened before them, wide and green and utterly silent. A single bird crossed the pale sky. They descended slowly, mindful of the loose stones, and did not look back at the mountains they had left.

By noon the heat was tremendous. They rested in the shade of an old wall whose origins none of them could name, and shared the last of the water.

¹ A reference to the well-known opening; see the notes for full context.

Chapter Two

The city, when they reached it, was smaller than the stories had promised. Its famous towers were half in ruins, and the great market square held only a handful of quiet stalls.² Still, it was a city, and after the empty country it felt like a kind of miracle.

They found lodging above a bakery. The **warm smell of bread** rose through the floorboards all night, and for the first time in weeks they slept without dreaming of the road.

What happened next is the subject of the *remainder of this account*, which the careful reader will find both stranger and more ordinary than any rumour yet recorded.

² The market had, in earlier centuries, been the largest for a hundred miles.